

The pool of potential recruits into the administration was thus widened, but civil servants still received a very conservative education based on the Four Books and Five Classics of Confucianism and a selection of neo-Confucian works that expounded the virtues of loyalty to the emperor and adherence to Chinese tradition. Innovation was discouraged and bureaucrats became set in their ways. Those who were perceived as having stepped outside their brief were publicly flogged, sometimes to death.

This maltreatment of public servants was a sign of the cruel side of Hongwu's personality. He was also violently paranoid, and vicious in his suppression of dissent. In 1382, he established a secret police, the Embroidered Brocade Guard, whose 16,000 officers stamped out all signs of resistance. The Guard's reach and influence was wide, and as a result, until the very last years of its rule, the Ming dynasty experienced no significant rebellions by either the military or the aristocracy.

International diplomacy

The dynasty's self-confidence appeared to grow even further under Hongwu's successor, Yongle (reigned 1402–1424), who

moved the capital from Nanjing to Beijing, and embarked on an ambitious program of reconstruction and public works, including measures to improve the navigability of the Grand Canal. He also built the extravagant Forbidden City, which housed an imperial palace complex containing more than 9,000 rooms.

Yongle's initially aggressive foreign policy led to four campaigns against Mongolia and an attack on Annam (Vietnam) in 1417 that resulted in its incorporation into the Ming Empire. He also sought recognition from the rulers of faraway states: between 1405 and 1433, he launched six large-scale maritime expeditions to Southeast Asia, East Africa, and Arabia. Led by the great fleet admiral Zheng He, their purpose was to confirm China's domination over the area by exacting tribute and other gestures of homage to the emperor.

The later Ming

However, the enormous cost of Zheng He's ambitious ventures put great strain on the treasury, and to ensure they would never be repeated, all records relating to them were destroyed. Official ideology »

The voyages of Zheng He

A Muslim of Mongol descent, Zheng He was captured by the Ming as a boy, castrated, and sent into the army, where he acquired military and diplomatic skills and distinguished himself as a junior officer. He went on to become an influential eunuch in the imperial court, and in 1405, Yongle chose him to lead a grandly conceived maritime expedition around the rim of the Indian Ocean, as both fleet admiral and diplomatic agent.

Over the next 28 years, Zheng He commanded one of the largest naval forces in history: the first mission had 63 vessels, including 440-ft- (130-m-) long "treasure ships" carrying more than 27,000 crew.

Although these voyages were dramatic in their conduct and scope—the last three sailed as far south as Mombasa on the east coast of Africa—they were not in any real sense commercial or exploratory ventures. Their intention was strictly diplomatic, designed to enhance China's prestige abroad and to extract

declarations of loyalty and exotic tributary gifts from Yongle.



This silk scroll records one of the most celebrated tribute gifts from Zheng He's voyages: a giraffe brought back from Africa in 1414.